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**Factors influencing the application of consumers' prior ecolabel knowledge in  
their green consumption**

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## **Abstract**

### **Purpose**

The study investigates factors influencing consumers' application of prior ecolabel knowledge in their green consumption, focusing on the primary grocery shopper of each household in Sweden.

### **Design/methodology/approach**

The authors used a qualitative research method with an inductive approach. Semi-structured interviews and thematic analysis have been used for data collection and analysis. A convenient sampling method was used in choosing the participants. Reliability and validity were considered to ensure the study's trustworthiness.

### **Findings**

The findings confirm that general environmental knowledge, eco-label knowledge, and awareness influence the application of consumers' prior ecolabel knowledge and purchase behaviour. Furthermore, our result showed altruism, health benefits, product attributes, label credibility are the motivating factors that influencing consumers' application of prior ecolabel knowledge. While product visibility, lack of knowledge, price sensitivity, and product availability are the constraint factors that influence in the consumer's application of prior ecolabel knowledge.

### **Originality/value**

The study examined factors that influence applying prior ecolabel knowledge in green consumer consumption in Sweden. Practitioners, marketers and prospect scholars will benefit from the study by understanding the gap between factors influencing the application of ecolabel knowledge in consumers' purchase behaviour.

*Keywords: Ecolabel knowledge, Environmental awareness, Green product attributes, purchase behaviour, green consumption*

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# 1. Introduction

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*This section aims to introduce and enlighten readers about the topic of eco-labels and background information that is paramount to the purpose of this thesis. Furthermore, the authors will discuss the thesis problem formulation and the research gap that ultimately led to our primary objective and research question.*

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## 1.1 Background

The awareness and interest for sustainable products among consumers' have heightened in recent years, and consumers' concerns for environmental protection have influenced them to purchase more sustainable products (Shin et al., 2021). Due to environmental degradation caused by excessive consumption resulting from rapid economic growth. Green consumption has become more practical and a necessity to mitigate constraints on both resources and the environment (Menghua et al., 2021). To respond to the changes in consumers' consumption, marketers have produced more than 450 ecolabels worldwide, sponsored and administered by governments, business associations, and non-government organisations (NGOs) (Darnall et al., 2018).

Ecolabels are a communication tool provided by manufacturers to help consumer make decisions regarding choosing environmentally friendly products. And to inform them of the manufacturing process (Nguyen-Viet 2022). They are seals or symbols created to help consumers identify ecologically superior products and boost their confidence when making a pro-environmental purchase (Darnall et al., 2018).



Bra Miljöval

*Figure 1: Example of a Swedish ecolabel*

Ecolabels can be classified into two types, type I and type II. Type I ecolabels evaluate the environmental quality of a product and compare it with the rest of the products, intending to encourage consumers to switch towards a more environmentally friendly consumption habit. Their sole aim is to certify products and their production process according to specific criteria related to the entire life cycle of the product (Galarraga Gallastegui 2002).

They are usually government-supported and are products of third-party certification programs. Type II labels mostly contain one-sided environmental information claims made by manufacturers, distributors, and importers and often refer to a specific product attribute such as 'CFC' free (Galarraga Gallastegui 2002). In addition, ecolabels designs are usually dependent on sponsorships, proprietorship arrangements, authentication bodies, and governance structures (Gorton et al., 2021).

Furthermore, prior research shows that factors such as affirmation from peers, product visibility, consumer insight, and inclusions affect ecolabel effectiveness (Calderon-Monge et al., 2020). Likewise, the effect of sustainability information on consumers' purchase intention and behaviour varies, depending on which type of consumers they are and what product categories the information is about (Butkeviciene et al., 2008).

O'Rourke & Ringer (2015) found that sustainability information has more effect on direct consumers, who are consumers that intentionally sort out sustainability information. And have less impact on non-direct users, which means that providing consumers with information on sustainability or having ecolabel indicators on a product will likely have a limited effect in influencing their behaviour. Unless consumers apply this information with other existing consumer decision-making processes, such as consumers intentionally using their knowledge about ecolabels at the point of purchase.

Although consumer knowledge about ecolabels has increased, this knowledge might not necessarily translate into purchase behaviours because of various barriers. Consumers often do not notice ecolabels on products, as they are usually time-pressed when shopping (Klaus G. Grunert, 2011). According to Klaus G. Grunert (2011), Other barriers that influence consumers'

application of prior eco-label knowledge are the trade-off between products with ecolabel seals and other criteria such as higher prices, product prioritisation, and lastly, lack of motivation from consumers.

## **1.2 Problem Statement**

According to Martínez García de Leaniz et al. (2018), consumers with a high level of green consciousness will develop positive behavioural intentions such as applying ecolabel knowledge, revisiting or repurchasing eco-labelled products, and willingness to pay for them. The study of Gaspar Ferreira and Fernandes (2021) likewise confirmed that the higher environmental consciousness a consumer has, the more loyal the consumer would become to buying green products. This has shown that there is a lot of research on how ecolabel influences consumer behaviour. However, they are primarily on consumer perception and quality of ecolabel products information (Kumar et al., 2021). Therefore, the factors influence the application of consumers' prior ecolabel knowledge in their green consumption are still remain to explore.

Calderon-Monge et al. (2021) suggest that other researchers should study the extent of consumer awareness and their application of ecolabels knowledge. Especially within different product sectors, to understand whether responsible consumers who attach importance to ecolabels betrays a cognitive bias. ElHaffar et al. (2020) likewise highlighted how, over the past few years, most of the research on green consumption utilises quantitative research methods and how future research needs to apply qualitative research methodology.

In this research, the authors will use the knowledge-attitude-behavioural model (KAB) to analyse factors that influence the application of consumers' prior ecolabel knowledge in their green consumption. Furthermore, the authors will examine the relationship between consumers' prior ecolabel knowledge and green consumption. The KAB model theorises that consumers first search for a set of knowledge, which results in either a negative or positive attitude towards the target behaviour (Dhir et al., 2021).

The researchers have decided to use the KAB model because past scholars have used it to investigate pro-environmental behaviour (Dhir et al., 2021). In addition, the KAB model will

offer an insight into factors that influence the application of consumers' prior ecolabel knowledge in their green consumption

### **1.3 Purpose and research questions**

This thesis explores the gap identified in the study of (Calderon-Monge et al., 2021). In their study, Calderon-Monge et al. (2021) mentioned how future research should investigate the extent of consumer awareness and their application of ecolabels knowledge. Especially within different product sectors. To clarify, consumers' application of prior knowledge means the way that consumer applies their prior knowledge, which reference to accumulated knowledge retrieved from related behaviours such as past purchase experience, environment, and education. Therefore, this research explores this gap by examining what factors influence consumers' application of prior ecolabel knowledge in their green consumption.

Hence, the formulation of the following research question:

*RQ[1] What factors influence the application of consumers' prior ecolabel knowledge in their green consumption?*

### **1.4 Limitation**

The limitations of this study are cognitive bias. Since the selected sample, who claim to know about the ecolabel, might confuse ecolabel or perceive it with something else such as greenwashing. Moreover, the chosen participants are consumers who live in Sweden. For this reason, the result will not be generalisable to consumers outside of Sweden. Also, the result cannot be applied to other green product sectors, such as electronic products, since this research aims to examine factors that influence the application of prior ecolabel knowledge on consumers' groceries purchase behaviour.

## 2. Literature Review

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*This section aims to acquaint readers with a deeper understanding of prior research concerning the topics relevant to the thesis. The authors will use research on fundamental notions to give a deeper understanding of the topic. The literature review will explain consumers' environmental awareness and consciousness, environmental and ecolabel knowledge.*

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### 2.1 Consumers' Environmental Awareness and Consciousness

Environmental awareness refers to the acknowledgement that ecological issues exist. It induces individuals to become more active in environmentally-friendly behaviour. (Xu, 2020). While consciousness refers to “attitudes that reflect that person's consistent evaluation, feeling, and tendency toward that thing or concept”. Thus, environmental consciousness is the psychological state that reflects the ecological commitment of an individual (Huang et al., 2014). In this study, the author claims that consumer environmental awareness and consciousness refer to the understanding of ecolabel, the current ecological issues, and their impact.

Consumers' environmental awareness has increased due to severe ecological issues (Martínez García de Leaniz et al., 2018; Huang et al., 2014). Likewise, prior research has shown that environmental perception and awareness impact consumers' buying decisions. Therefore, consumers with environmental awareness tend to support sustainable products because they want to solve and lessen environmental issues (Wang et al., 2020).

Previous research shows that consumers demonstrate environmental support based on their environmental consciousness and value. Therefore, consumers would often reject incentives such as discounts for green products due to their firm determination to support the environment (Huang et al., 2014). They likewise perceived receiving incentives as losing control of their intention to purchase green products and perceived it as a forced behaviour instead of an intentional one (Huang et al., 2014).



In addition, consumers' environmental consciousness is unaffected by greenwashing, except for consumers who are over 35 years old (Gaspar Ferreira et al., 2021). This is because the younger generation is often more knowledgeable about environmental issues than the older generation, especially, since younger generations get exposed to ecological knowledge early (Gaspar Ferreira et al., 2021).

Martínez García de Leaniz et al. (2018) discuss how consumer environmental consciousness is related to a psychological factor. It is an individual tendency to engage in environmentally supportive behaviour and concern for the community, often beyond oneself, also referred to as altruistic behaviour.

Altruistic behaviour occurs when one holds personal norms (such as supportive environmental behaviour), which is the consequence of one's awareness and engagement in altruism. Martínez García de Leaniz et al. (2018) likewise discuss that when charitable concerns influence consumers, the need for self-esteem and self-awareness occurs. This often leads consumers to a state of active caring. Thus, consumers who perceive themselves as ecological supportive will prefer to purchase products that have been environmentally certified. Choosing eco-friendly products would reflect them as an environmental self-caring individual (Martínez García de Leaniz et al., 2018).

Furthermore, the higher the environmental attribute influences a consumer, the higher the consumer will become environmentally conscious. As a result, a consumer who has a high level of green consciousness will develop positive behavioural intentions such as applying eco-label knowledge, influencing others, revisiting or repurchasing ecolabel products, and willingness to pay for them (Martínez García de Leaniz et al., 2018). The study of Gaspar Ferreira and Fernandes (2021) likewise confirmed that the higher environmental consciousness a consumer has, the more loyal the consumer would become to buying green products.

## **2.2 Consumers' Environmental Knowledge**

Environmental knowledge represents an individual's awareness of the impact of ecosystems on society and the level of consumer knowledge about environmental issues. In addition, it contains the consumer's knowledge and ability to identify the ecologically related symbols and tags (Amoako et al., 2020).

Past research argues that environmental knowledge is a subset of ecological awareness, and it has two appearances: cognitive awareness and affective awareness (Sharma & Foropon, 2019). The author defined mental awareness as the knowledge-based awareness of the environment, while affective awareness means the awareness gained through perception. Prior research has shown both appearances to indirectly affect individuals' behavioural changes (Sharma & Foropon, 2019).

In addition, existing behaviour studies claim that knowledge is more critical in behaviour change than other factors such as the focus of control, attitude, and verbal commitment. It also shows an indirect relationship between knowledge and emotional engagement, leading to a proactive understanding of the environment and this understanding of behaviours that support the environment (Sharma & Foropon, 2019).

Lack of knowledge is detrimental to consumers' behaviour. For example, a Canadian consumer study shows that more than 60% of Canadian consumers do not have pro-environmental behaviour due to a lack of knowledge (Amoako et al., 2020). Therefore, environmental knowledge has an essential role in consumer behaviour.

## **2.3 Ecolabel knowledge**

Ecolabel knowledge plays an essential role in helping consumers realise the purpose and benefits of environmentally friendly products (Thøgersen et al., 2010). Therefore, consumers must have ecolabel knowledge to interpret information on these products since manufacturers write this information precisely. For example, the figure below shows the Nordic Swan, usually seen on detergents and toilet paper (Svanen.se). Thus, consumers with high ecolabel knowledge are more

likely to purchase environmentally labelled products than consumers with low knowledge (Kumar et al., 2021).



*Figure 2: Nordic Swan ecolabel*

When consumers make environmentally conscious and reasoned purchase decisions, general environmental knowledge is not enough for ecologically conscious consumers. Instead, they need product-specific environmental knowledge, such as eco-label knowledge, to provide accurate and appropriate information (Taufique et al., 2016). This means consumers have to know about the existence of ecolabels, understand what they mean, and also trust the pieces of information written on them (Thøgersen, 2000). Therefore, ecolabel knowledge is specific information about a product or service concerning its overall benefits, such as the absence of non-toxic ingredients and how cartons are recycled (International Standards Organisation, 2019).

Furthermore, ecolabel knowledge considerably influences the process of product assessment and consumer purchase decisions (Riskos et al., 2021). This statement supports the KAB model, which shows that knowledge impacts behaviour change (Yi & Hohashi, 2018). Therefore, consumer lack of knowledge would decrease ecolabel purchase behaviour due to a lack of eco-friendly guarantees, such as eco-labels (Nilsson et al., 2004).

Prior research likewise demonstrated the importance of ecolabel knowledge, such as enhancing transparency and consumer trust in eco-friendly claims (Thøgersen et al., 2010).

Finally, for ecolabel to have optimal effectiveness, consumers need to understand the information they receive to increase product credibility (Taufique et al., 2016). More importantly, ecolabel knowledge reduces the consumer's dilemma during purchase, increases trust in the product, and establishes positive associations between knowledge and confidence in buying behaviours (Taufique et al., 2016).

## **2.4 Green Products & Attributes**

Green products are environmentally friendly and market-oriented products that cause minimum environmental damage. The manufacturing process of green products connects to a product improvement process formulated to consider the damage inflicted on the environment throughout their lifecycle (Cooper-Ordoñez et al., 2018).

Research by Sharma & Foropon (2019) explains that green product purchases should be considered a cost-benefit choice from a free-market perspective. Meaning when consumers buy green products, product attributes, among others, are factors that determine if they buy them or not (Calderon-Monge et al., 2021).

Furthermore, results from the study by Gan et al. (2008) showed that product attributes such as quality, price, and the willingness to pay are factors first considered when making green purchase decisions by environmentally conscious consumers. Although consumers think of various product attributes during their purchase decision, product quality, price, and brand image seem to take the forefront for most consumers.

### ***2.4.1 Product Quality***

Green product quality is one of the dimensions of product functionality that consumers often consider when selecting either eco-labelled products or conventional products within the same product group (Calderon-Monge et al., 2021). Although products with eco-labels are satisfactory,

according to Calderon-Monge et al., (2021), they must likewise adhere to specific minimum standards for consumers to purchase them.

Furthermore, products with eco-labels must not be inferior in quality to other conventional or non-eco-labelled options, especially when they have the same economic value. Consumers will often look for a higher rate when deciding which one to buy. This is especially important when such products fall into the food items categories (Calderon-Monge et al., 2021; Magnusson et al., 2001) shows how other quality factors such as ‘good taste’ ‘long-shelf life’ and ‘healthy’ often influence consumer purchase behaviour.

### **2.4.2 Price**

Price signifies the economic value that is the cost-benefit and financial value involved in a product trade. Price to consumers of green products often acts as a function of telling how high is the quality of the product concerning its attributes. This is especially common within the organic food category because of the functional attributes of being environmentally friendly, healthier and pesticides free (Watanabe et al., 2020). Among consumers, most especially first-time buyers of eco-labelled products, product prices and presumption about how eco-labelled products are more expensive are often the two factors that counteract consumer choices of eco-labelled products (Watanabe et al., 2020).

Furthermore, (Calderon-Monge et al. 2021; Carrero and Valor 2015) show an inverse relationship between consumers’ purchase intention of environmentally friendly products and price; however, their research further explained how consumers place less value on price and show more willingness towards responsible purchase. When consumers identify with product values and these products satisfy their needs, they often attach less attention to their costs.

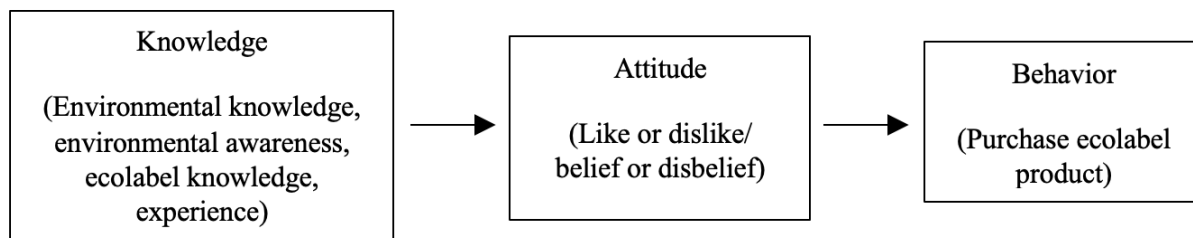
## **2.5 Theoretical framework**

### **The KAB Model**

Kallgren and Woods first proposed the knowledge-attitude-behaviour model (1986). The model infers that before individuals develop an attitude toward a target behaviour, consumers first need a set of knowledge. Consumers first look for a group of knowledge that will either result in a

positive or negative attitude towards the target behaviour (Dhir et al., 2021). Furthermore, the KAB model shows that accumulated knowledge is retrieved from related behaviours such as experience, environment, education, etc. It describes the role of knowledge in behaviour change and knowledge accumulation and how the collection of such knowledge will lead to a change in attitude and eventual behaviour change (Khan et al., 2011).

The KAB model will help understand what factors influence consumers' application of prior ecolabel knowledge in their green consumption in this study. In addition, the KAB model will be used to demonstrate the relationship between knowledge, attitude, and consumer purchase behaviour. As shown in the figure below, the KAB model will illustrate how the knowledge application process influences behaviour through the link of attitude.



*Figure 3: KAB model*

Knowledge is a justified true belief obtained through experience and education (Bolisani & Bratianu, 2017; Fabrigar et al., 2006). Furthermore, the amount of information in one's memory can affect how one interprets preferences (Riskos et al., 2021). Moreover, knowledge directly affects mental outlook and behaviour through attitude (Bolisani & Bratianu, 2017). Therefore, it is a crucial factor due to its influence and the fact that it enables the consumer to realise the benefit of eco-label products.

In this study, consumers' ecolabel knowledge and environmental knowledge represent the KAB model's knowledge component. Therefore, the authors will interpret and analyse ecolabel awareness and label identification as knowledge. At the same time, the authors will interpret environmental knowledge as the extent of consumers' awareness of environmental issues that causes them to act (Dhir et al., 2021).

Attitude refers to “an enduring set of beliefs about an object that predisposes people to behave in a particular way toward the object” (Riskos et al., 2021). It is a response to a stimulus composed of cognitive, affective, and behavioural components, the mental judgment of one’s opinion toward the object (belief and disbelief). At the same time, the affective component is the emotional response toward the thing (like and dislike), and the behavioural feature is an individual response to the attitude (Newcomb, 1961). In addition, attitude highly affects behaviour and choices. Therefore, a positive attitude towards an ecolabel can be a starting point for green consumption. Therefore, attitude in this study will be interpreted and analysed as consumers’ cognitive belief of how the purchase of ecolabel products minimises the harm made to the environment.

Behaviour refers to how a person acts toward something subconsciously or consciously, such as consumers applying their prior eco-label knowledge in their green consumption (Bolisani & Bratianu, 2017). However, environmental knowledge does not always lead to the adoption of pro-environmental behaviours (Dhir et al., 2021). Likewise, external factors such as cost-effectiveness and internal factors are why consumers engage in pro-environmental behaviour. (Sharma & Foropon, 2019). Therefore, in this study, the behaviour component of the KAB theory will be considered as the consumer application or lack of application of prior ecolabel knowledge and purchase or lack of acquisition of eco-label products.

### 3. Methodology

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*In this section, the authors will explain the study design and study approach. Then, the methods used for data collection, such as in-depth interviews, the qualitative approach method, and convenience samples, will be presented and discussed more thoroughly. Finally, the researcher will explain the process for data analysis and ethical considerations.*

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#### 3.1 Research design & Research approach

According to Kusiák (2020), a research design is a plan that defines how to answer key research questions. Therefore, this study will be qualitative with an inductive approach to explore what factors influence the application of consumers' prior ecolabel knowledge in their green consumption. A qualitative research method is a research method that allows a researcher to investigate and explore the quality of relationships, situations, activities or materials (Aspers & Corte, 2019).

The authors used a qualitative method to understand the relationship between factors that influences the application of consumers' prior ecolabel knowledge and their purchase behaviour. They also used a thematic method to analyse data collected through semi-structured interviews, literature reviews, and the KAB model. Furthermore, a thematic approach is used for transcription and analysis to ensure objectivity and avoid researcher influence and bias (Aspers & Corte, 2019).

In addition, 9 participants that are leading buyers of groceries in a household irrespective of gender in Sweden were interviewed using Zoom and in a one-on-one setting. Likewise, the authors ensured a few underlying assumptions before interviewing the participants, such as confirming that all participants are consumers who purchase eco-labelled products ranging from fresh produce to other product categories and have prior knowledge of eco-label.



## **3.2 Data collection**

The data collection contained primary data and secondary data. Since this research is qualitative, the authors used Zoom and one-to-one interviews to collect all primary data. It is a valuable way to gain insight into people's perceptions, understanding, and experiences of a given incident. (Ryan et al., 2009). Therefore, the researcher uses semi-structured interviews since it is beneficial in achieving this type of surface (Galletta & Cross, 2013).

Semi-structured interviews allow interviewers to compare the participant on the same set of questions and gives the researcher the flexibility to track new topics as needed for the research purpose (Barriball & While, 1993). As for the participants, the authors adopted convenient sampling due to the limited time. Convenient sampling is a sample taken from a portion of the population that is nearby and convenient. It's an unlikely random sampling and requires fewer requirements. The authors collect previous studies on this research topic from Google Scholar and Primo for secondary data. Both platforms are reviewed for good research and have a wide range of resources to help this research accomplish its aim.

### ***3.2.1 Interview structure***

The authors interviewed the participants in three sections. For the first section, the authors asked the participants some general questions regarding their knowledge and awareness of the environment. In addition, to gain further insight, the authors also asked about broad environmental issues to observe the participant's knowledge and attitude toward the environment.

The authors asked the participants to describe their grocery shopping routine for food and household products in the second phase. To allow the participant to express their lifestyle and enable the authors to understand the reason behind some specific behaviour in grocery shopping, such as time-pressed, parenting, and health requirements. Furthermore, the authors asked Participants questions about eco-labels, and if they recognised the eco-label figure, we showed them. This figure contains ecolabels generally seen in a supermarket in Sweden. Furthermore, the authors asked the participants to describe which products they have mostly seen ecolabels on

and if they understand their meaning. This phase will focus on the shopping process and ecolabel's knowledge and recognition.

The final phase focuses on how participants applied their prior ecolabel knowledge and the participant actions at the point of purchase. The authors asked participants to describe their purchasing decisions and buying process from product evaluation to purchase. In addition, some questions require the participant to reflect on their post-purchase experience. The authors asked participants these questions to understand how prior ecolabel knowledge influences consumers' purchase behaviour.

### ***3.2.2 Interview respondents***

The selected 9 participants are individuals who are the primary grocery shopper in their household and who support green product consumption. The selection method is regardless of gender, race, age, and occupation. However, the first participant is male, and the other 8 participants are female. Brief information about the participant is below.

#### ***Participant 1***

A 40 years old male. Currently works in an IT consultancy firm as an IT technician. According to his memory, the participant has been exposed to eco-labels since he was 12-13 years old.

#### ***Participant 2***

She is a 50 years old female working at an elderly home.

#### ***Participant 3***

She is an adult female who works as a librarian. According to the participant, she has been aware of ecolabels and buying eco-label products for about 30 years.

#### ***Participant 4***

She is a middle-aged female who works as a teacher. According to the participant, she has been aware of eco-labels for a long time but only occasionally buys ecolabel products.

#### ***Participant 5***

A 22-year-old female student. The participant explained that she had been aware of eco-labels since middle school.

#### ***Participant 6***

A 23 years old female. She is currently studying at a Swedish university. She has been exposed to eco-labels since high school (she did research on ecolabels as a part of the high school project).

#### ***Participant 7***

a 43-year old female who is working as a dental nurse. She was first exposed to eco-labels when society started to consider them.

#### ***Participant 8***

A 21-year-old female currently studying at a Swedish university. The participant explained that she was exposed to eco-labels since high school (studying about ecolabel as a part of her education)

#### ***Participant 9***

She is a 67-year-old female who is retired and worked as a volunteer in artistic works. She explained that she had known about eco-labels for about seven years.

### **3.3 Data analysis**

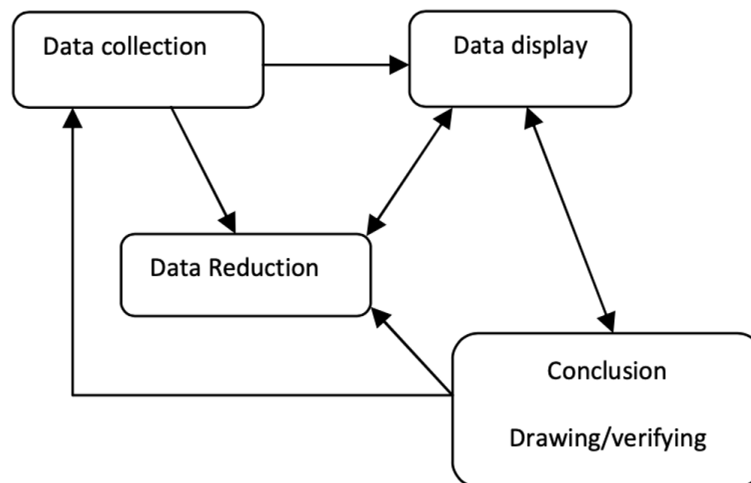
According to the data collection, the data collected were qualitative data which usually depend on interpretation for analysing. Thematic analysis is considered optimal for any study that tries to analyse the data by interpretation. It is a standard method for identifying and interpreting the pattern and theme and detecting the factors influencing the participant's matter (Clarke & Braun, 2017). Also, it provides an accessible and systematic procedure to code and category themes from qualitative data. It allows the researcher to relate the theme frequency to the entire content, providing preciseness and enhancing

the whole meaning of the research (Alhojailan, 2012).

However, thematic analysis data are independent of the existing themes. Meaning thematic analysis can be adapted to any research. Its objective requires only clarification from the participants (Alhojailan, 2012).

Additionally, since thematic analysis identifies patterns within and cross information related to the participants' life experiences, perspectives, and behaviours (Ozuem et al., 2022), the authors applied thematic analysis to explore the relationship between factors that influences consumers' application of prior ecolabel knowledge in their purchase behaviour. The authors used thematic analysis to analyse the data in this study because of its suitability for the research objective.

Although researchers widely use thematic analysis in their research, there is no precise approach method. Miles and Huberman (1994) developed the introductory model of the thematic analysis process. The model consists of three main steps: data reduction, data display, and data drawing and conclusions.



*Figure 4: Thematic analysis model by Miles and Huberman (1994)*

### ***Data reduction***

Data reduction involves the process of selection, simplification, and data conversion, which is a coding technique where data collected from participants are assigned, no matter whether it's a single sentence or more, to the tabular. The purpose of coding is to identify the connection between different parts of the data.

The author used the three phases of data reduction Miles & Huberman (1994) suggested in this study. The first phase is to tabulate the data collected and organise it, then use a table to illustrate the discoveries. In the second phase, the researcher should keep the study's objective in mind when highlighting the participants' sentences. Lastly, in the third phase, the highlighted sentence should be divided into more minor themes as the first level of themes.

Finally, Miles and Huberman (1994) advised classifying the first level of themes into the second level of theme. Alhojailan (2012) suggested that the researcher revise the data several times during the data reduction process to see the big picture and the standard connection between each participant, preventing the decisive conclusion.

### ***Data display***

The data display stage is to visualise information through quotations, numbers, and descriptive text (Ozuem et al., 2022). The data relating to each question should be organised and presented accordingly. In addition, the researchers should analyse the examined interpretations using supporting evidence as it allows the researchers to explore any differences, similarities, and relationships in the data. This stage aims to have a clearer view of the data and prevent data overload in the analysis process. Furthermore, this stage complements the data reduction. Thus, it cannot be separated (Alhojailan, 2012).

### ***Data drawing and conclusion***

Data drawing and conclusion is the last stage of the Miles and Huberman model (1994). This stage provides precise results from the displayed data. Alhojailan (2012) suggested grouping the

information that can go together or identify the relationship between factors and variables. This conclusion is also complementary and cannot be separated from previous stages.

### **3.4 Reliability and validity**

Validity and reliability are vital aspects of all research. It helps ensure that the results are trustworthy. However, the credibility of qualitative research is not the same as in quantitative analysis. In qualitative research, reliability is related to the consistency, stability, and repeatability of a participant's record and the researcher's ability to collect the data accurately. In other words, it refers to a researcher's skill to consistently produce the same results during repeated testing sessions (Brink, 1993). While validity in qualitative research is "construct validity". In addition, It is the fundamental concepts, questions, or assumptions that determine what data is needed to collect and what is the appropriate way to organise (Golafshani, 2003).

The researcher has ensured that the participants know the research objective and the requirements needed to participate in the data collecting process in this research. Also, the researcher designed the interview questions to suit both the research purpose and in a structure that allows the participant to express themselves adequately. This ensures rich data is collected to increase data reliability and validity in the analysing process. The researchers made sure that the most appropriate methodology was used for data collection, as these are the approaches Brink (1993) suggested for the researcher to use to increase the reliability and validity of their study.

One crucial step in thematic analysis is the reliability and validity of thematic analysis to evaluate the "theme" to ensure that it represents the entire content; therefore, it is essential to verify the validity of themes at the beginning and end of the data analysis (Alhojailan, 2012). Validation is necessary for analysing the data since it provides accurate and reliable data for each coding stage. Also, it reduces the possibility of errors. In this study, the authors ensured every theme process was validated and repeated (Brink, 1993).

### **3.5 Ethical consideration**

Ensuring participants' rights and privacy in a research study is obligatory. Therefore, the researcher needs to be aware of the ethical considerations regarding conducting research

(Voltelen et al., 2017). Despite gaining reliable and valuable responses from the participants, the researchers ensured that they were conscientious about participants' preferences and comfortability. Therefore, the researchers gave the participants consent forms, which informed them about the purpose of the study, and that participants would be recorded. Furthermore, the researcher ensured that all participants read and consented to partake in the research study in the first stage (Hussey et al., 1997).

The researchers considered the vocabulary used in writing the questions while considering the participants' level of perception and linguistic skills. It is imperative to use non-threatening words and familiar words in presenting the interview questions rather than unfamiliar words (Hussey et al., 1997). In addition, researchers ensured that participants were not pressured or asked unethical questions, so the interview questions were structured from simple to complex (Hussey et al., 1997).

Furthermore, the researchers sent a copy of the recorded interviews to the participants to get their feedback to let participants assess what they said and get further input from them (Hussey et al., 1997). Finally, the researchers ensured confidentiality and privacy regarding participants' data when writing their final reports and that other authors' intellectual property was referenced and respected (Eungoo Kang et al., 2021).

## 4. Findings and Data Analysis

*This section presents the results and analysis of the interview. The topic discussed is environmental knowledge & awareness, ecolabel knowledge & awareness and factors influencing the application of prior knowledge.*

| First level of theme                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               | Second level of theme                      | Global theme                                  |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>It doesn't look too promising, certain things are. catastrophic.</li> <li>I think it is terrible.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                | The awareness towards environmental issues | General environmental knowledge and awareness |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>The issue is what type of world my kids will grow up in, and I don't think current strategies like recycling impact large-scale environmental problems.</li> </ul>                                                                                          | Concern                                    |                                               |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Some farmers use pesticides, and it affects the climate.</li> <li>Environmental changes such as global warming. It's causing the temperature to rise.</li> <li>There is so much overconsumption in the society which is bad for the environment.</li> </ul> | Environmental knowledge                    |                                               |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>I mostly see these labels every time I go shopping for groceries.</li> <li>I think I have seen G garant, Svenskt sigill.</li> <li>Association of ecolabels to having special requirement.</li> </ul>                                                        | Ecolabel awareness                         | Ecolabel awareness & knowledge                |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>More awareness of ecolabels in fresh produce and cleaning products categories; milk, bread, banana, detergent.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                   | Ecolabel product category                  |                                               |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>I probably buy the eco-label product out of feeling that I do make an impression that I help to you know to sustain the environment.</li> <li>I also buy them because they are healthier and because they cause less damage to the environment.</li> </ul>  | Attitude toward ecolabel product purchase  |                                               |



|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |                                                 |                                                                                |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>I apply prior eco-label knowledge only when faced I see products that have one.</li> <li>I think that shops have a big responsibility to show the eco-label product and place them where people can easily see them.</li> </ul> | Product visibility                              | (Constraint)<br>Factors that influence application of prior Ecolabel knowledge |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Maybe because we aren't as informed.</li> <li>Less informed about the purpose/objective of manufactures of products with eco-labels on them.</li> </ul>                                                                         | Lack of knowledge                               |                                                                                |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>It depends on the income/economy also. "How much does it cost?"</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                      | Price sensitivity                               |                                                                                |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Sometimes eco-label products are not available at all, so when these labels become available, they get recognized more and it easier to use your knowledge.</li> </ul>                                                          | Product availability                            |                                                                                |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>It feels good when you buy a labeled product then you know that you at least maybe did something good for the environment hopefully.</li> </ul>                                                                                 | Altruism                                        | (Motivators)<br>Factors that influence application of prior ecolabel knowledge |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Then I have diabetes. So, I even need to look for the fat or so, so I need to use my knowledge a bit.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                | Health issues & benefit                         |                                                                                |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Product selection. I try to use my knowledge about the product I buy before to decide if I should by it or not.</li> </ul>                                                                                                      | Product attributes (quality, taste, shelf-live) |                                                                                |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>These labels have been around so long that we almost exclusively know that they are good.</li> <li>I look for the mark that I knew are real.</li> </ul>                                                                         | Credibility                                     |                                                                                |

## 4.1 General Environmental Awareness & environmental knowledge

### *Awareness toward environmental issues*

Participants were asked about their current environment view to start the discussion. All participants demonstrated a level of awareness towards the environment and highlighted how vulnerable it is and how society keeps taking and using resources without replenishing them. In addition, the participants described the state of the environment with words like "terrible" and "catastrophic".

*"It doesn't look too promising, certain things are catastrophic." (Participant 2)*

*"I think it is terrible." (Participant 9).*

### ***Concern***

Environmental concern was another dimension in which the participants portrayed environmental awareness. All the participants expressed their concern about the environment and pointed out the environmental issues that they were most concerned about, such as “climate change” and “Deforestation”. Furthermore, participants demonstrated awareness of future environmental challenges and showed concern about how upcoming generations will suffer devastating consequences if the society at large does nothing. However, some participants think that current strategies to minimise environmental damages, such as recycling plastic, aren't as effective as we all seem to believe.

*“The issue is what type of world my kids will grow up in, and I don't think current strategies like recycling impact large-scale environmental problems.” (Participant 1)*

### ***Environmental knowledge***

All participants demonstrated environmental knowledge based on the acquired information, personal research, and experiences, such as seasonal changes resulting from global warming. The participants also shared deep insight about various ecological issues, such as climate change, pollution, deforestation, and global warming. Finally, the participants explained the effect of these environmental issues and suggested ways to mitigate environmental damage. A few of the participants' suggestions were creating environmental awareness, minimising waste, and reducing overconsumption.

*“I think if we can think about how we travel, what we buy, and then we can recycle plastic and paper” (Participant 3)*

## **4.2 Ecolabel awareness & Ecolabel knowledge**

All participants showed a relatively high level of eco-label awareness. The authors asked the participants if they knew the labels were called eco-labels. They all have agreed to know that. They were shown a couple of eco-labels and asked if they recognised them. Some of the participants can identify the name of the ecolabels and indicate which product they have seen

them on. Participants demonstrated that they all had been exposed to eco-labels at a very young age 6 out of 9 participants answered that they had been exposed to eco-labels since high school.

*“When I was younger, in high school, I did a project group about the economy and the eco-labels about creating a company that has zero waste. So, I research a lot about eco-labels and their meanings.” (Participant 6)*

*“In high school because my teacher taught about eco-labels during a society project lecture.” (Participant 8).*

Concerning participants' Eco-label knowledge, the participants showed a relatively average level of ecolabel knowledge when asked about them. Although participants were able to discern that ecolabel products are products produced in a less harmful way, none of the participants is knowledgeable about the message manufacturers are trying to pass across. Participants described eco-labelled products as good quality, products produced in a less environmentally damaging way, expensive and more environmentally friendly.

*“I wouldn't say that I know particularly well of the story or the background behind the labels, or what they are, you know manufacturing or what they want to change with their marketing and the labelling.” (Participants 1)*

Furthermore, All participants indicated that they make more purchases of eco-label products in the fresh produce (vegetable, tomatoes), fruits (bananas, oranges), cleaning products (detergents), and dairy products (milk, eggs, cheese) products categories. Therefore, the participants apply their knowledge more in those categories than in other product categories.

*“I am more picky when it comes to my fresh produce.” (Participant 6)*

### 4.3 Motivating factor influencing the application of consumers' prior ecolabel

The following themes were the identified motivating factors influencing the application of consumers' prior ecolabel knowledge. They are altruism, health benefits, product attributes and label credibility.

#### *Altruism*

Altruism is one of the factors that participants highlighted to influence them when they purchase and apply prior ecolabel knowledge in their consumption. When purchasing eco-label products, the participants explained that they have to use their previous ecolabel knowledge, usually derived from past purchase experience. Furthermore, the participants stated that when they apply this knowledge, which generally leads to purchasing eco-label products, they become engulfed with good feelings about how they did something good for the environment.

*“It feels good when you buy a labelled product then you know that you at least maybe did something good for the environment hopefully.” (Participant 1)*

#### *Health Benefits*

The participants indicated that purchasing eco-label products is suitable for their health and the environment. Some participants have health issues, and they consider ecolabel products are a better choice for them. Therefore, the participants are motivated to apply prior ecolabel knowledge because they purchase for their health. Thus, product information and ecolabel knowledge are needed.

*“ I have diabetes. So I even need to look for the fat or so.” (Participant 2)*

#### *Product quality*

Another theme identified to influence participants' application of prior ecolabel knowledge is product quality. When participants explained their decision process and how they applied their knowledge, most of them said that they needed to use previous knowledge when they choose between eco-label or regular products. In addition, the participant pointed out that ecolabel products, especially those from the category of fresh produce and dairy products, have a shorter shelf-life. Therefore, to choose products with good quality and that taste good, they need to use the knowledge from a previous purchase.

*“when they get left out in the shop because no pesticides are used in the process of getting the food, it gets spoilt quicker” (Participant 1)*

*“When I buy a carrot and see eco-label on it, I think it's of good quality” (Participant 4)*

### ***Ecolabel credibility***

The final theme identified is ecolabel credibility. The participants explained that they trust ecolabels that have been around for a long time because they know what the companies behind them stand for. However, some of the participant's responses also include how not all the labels are authentic. Therefore they need to use their prior knowledge about ecolabels to discern which brands are original and which ones are fake. In addition, most of the participants recognised the eco-label shown during the interview, and some of them could identify the ecolabel. Therefore, the participants said previous ecolabel knowledge influences them when they consider whether the labels on the product are credible or not.

*“ I look for the labels that I know are real. I think some labels might not be real eco-label. But I know that they are real ones. So I try to look for the label that I know.” (Participant 3)*

## **4.4 Constraining factors influencing the application of consumers' prior ecolabel**

During the interview, the participants were asked what things prevented them from using their previous ecolabel knowledge. Product visibility, lack of knowledge, price sensitivity, and product availability were the identified constraining themes that influenced participants' application of prior ecolabel knowledge in their green consumption.

### ***Product Visibility***

Lack of eco-labelled products visibility is one of the forefront factors participants described influences the application of prior ecolabel knowledge. During the interview, the participants explained how eco-labelled products are usually not shown in conspicuous places in the store and how often it is difficult to locate them. Therefore, if they can't find the product, they won't be able to apply both their knowledge or even make a purchase.

In addition, the participants talked about how they are often in haste when they go grocery shopping, so if the product is not visible, they won't go around looking for it. Finally, participant 3 explained how the store has a responsibility to display these products more clearly. It will encourage consumers to buy them more and apply their knowledge more.

*"I mean, if I have two products to choose from and none of them are eco-label products, I wouldn't go looking for a third option with an eco-label, so if it is in the vicinity, yeah, it's gonna get snagged." (Participant 1)*

*"I think that shops have a big responsibility to show the eco-label products and place them where people can easily see them." (Participant 3)*

### **Price**

Price was the most talked-about theme. Participants talked about how eco-labelled products are expensive compared to regular products, so they always can't buy them. Therefore, they are unable to use ecolabel knowledge. In addition, 34% of the participants described that they are students, so they do not have a high income, so they can't buy products.

*"eco-labels are more costly." (Participant 6)*

*"There were always the prices that were a factor for using my knowledge and buying, you know, ecolabel consumer goods and the groceries. So that might discourage me at the beginning from choosing the products that may be 4kr or 5kr more expensive." (Participant 1)*

### **Lack of knowledge**

Lack of knowledge was the other factor that all the participants expressed influenced the application of their prior ecolabel knowledge. All the participants said that although they know that ecolabel means the products are produced in a less damaging way to the environment, they express how they do not know the specific information the manufacturer is trying to pass across. Therefore, it might be challenging to buy ecolabel products since they need to understand the message on the labels to know what they are supporting.

*“ I think It’s more about the information of the eco-label product. If they get information that using these will lessen the effect on the earth, they will buy them more and use their knowledge too.” (Participant 8)*

### ***Product Availability***

Product availability is the last theme identified to influence the application of participants’ prior ecolabel knowledge. The participants mentioned that sometimes ecolabel products are not available at the store. Thus, the participant could not purchase and use their ecolabel knowledge because the product is not present for them to consider.

*“Sometimes eco-label products are not available at all, so when these labels become available, they get recognised more and it is easier to use your knowledge.” (Participant 3)*

## 5. Discussion

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*The following section will discuss and combine the finding with the theory to better understand the results. Also, the authors will explain the managerial implication according to the findings.*

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The findings confirm that general environmental knowledge, eco-label knowledge, and awareness influence the application of consumers' prior ecolabel knowledge and purchase behaviour. These findings suggest that consumers must exhibit general environmental knowledge, eco-label knowledge, and awareness to carry out pro-environmental behaviour. Previous studies have found that consumer environmental awareness also impacts and enhances a positive green attitude, followed by positive ecological and behavioural intention (Martínez García de Leaniz et al., 2018).

Our results confirm this since it shows that consumer environmental and ecolabel awareness are essential and core foundations in determining factors that influence consumers' application of prior eco-label knowledge in their green consumption. Furthermore, our results showed that altruism, health benefits, product attributes, and ecolabel credibility factors motivate consumers to apply previous knowledge in their green consumption. On the other hand, the constraining aspects that prevent consumers from using their prior knowledge are price, product availability, product visibility, and lack of knowledge.

In addition, an exhibition of altruistic behaviour significantly influences the application of prior ecolabel knowledge in green consumer consumption. Altruism is an individual tendency to engage in environmentally supportive behaviour that is often beyond oneself (Martínez García de Leaniz et al., 2018). Participants described that being engulfed with good feelings about how they did something good for the environment is why they buy eco-label products and apply previous knowledge. This statement confirms what Martínez García de Leaniz et al. (2018) said about how consumers who choose eco-friendly products perceive themselves as environmentally self-caring individuals. Thus implying that consumers apply prior ecolabel knowledge in their green consumption because they believe that they can impact by reducing ecological degradation.



Health benefit is another motivating factor influencing ecolabel knowledge in green consumer consumption. Participants explained that purchasing eco-label products is suitable for their health and the environment. Therefore, they are motivated to use their expertise to choose the right products, thus confirming the kab theory that states that a set of knowledge leads to either a positive or negative attitude towards a target behaviour (Dhir et al., 2021). Therefore, consumers' knowledge about health benefits derived from buying ecolabel products motivates them to use their prior knowledge. Furthermore, ecolabel credibility also influences the application of consumers' knowledge. Additionally, respondents trust and connect credibility to ecolabels they are more familiar with, which affects the application of their prior knowledge.

Respondent has expressed how not all labels are credible and how they have to look for authentic brands since some labels are fake. This confirms what (Taufique et al., 2016) said about how general environmental knowledge is not enough for environmentally conscious consumers. Instead, they need product-specific knowledge, such as eco-label knowledge, that provides accurate and appropriate information, in this case, knowledge of how to differentiate fake labels from real ones.

Another factor affecting the application of consumers' prior knowledge is product attributes. Ecolabel attributes such as shorter shelf life, good taste, and higher quality influence consumers purchasing eco-label products. Therefore, respondent answers confirm what Calderon-Monge et al. (2021) said, that eco products must adhere to specific minimum standards for consumers to buy them. Our results further revealed the four main factors that negatively affect and prevent the consumer from applying their ecolabel knowledge: product visibility, lack of knowledge, price sensitivity, and the product's availability. The KAB model proposes that behaviour changes affect attitudes formed by knowledge (Khan et al., 2011).

According to Bolisani and Bratianu (2017), knowledge is a justified true belief obtained through experience and education. In this study, the participants have expressed their knowledge and experience when they confront ecolabel products. In addition, ecolabel visibility is another constraining factor that influences the application of consumers' prior knowledge. Participants express the challenge in locating eco-labelled products, implying that they could have a mildly

negative attitude towards applying ecolabel knowledge. Moreover, the lack of knowledge theme refers to the perception of unfamiliar and uncredible products since they haven't seen them before and there is no information about them at the store. Furthermore, all the participants mentioned that price is essential when purchasing eco-label products. Ecolabel products usually have a higher price. Therefore, the participant performs a negative attitude towards it. Lastly, the participant indicated that it is not every time ecolabel products are available. This means participants cannot purchase ecolabel products or apply their knowledge even though they intend to, thus, resulting in a negative attitude. These factors show how a negative attitude toward ecolabel products forms.

However, these factors form a negative attitude and a constraint to applying ecolabel knowledge. Therefore, since they have a negative attitude, they do not have the intention to purchase ecolabel products. And since they do not intend to buy ecolabel products, this will result in not applying the ecolabel knowledge.

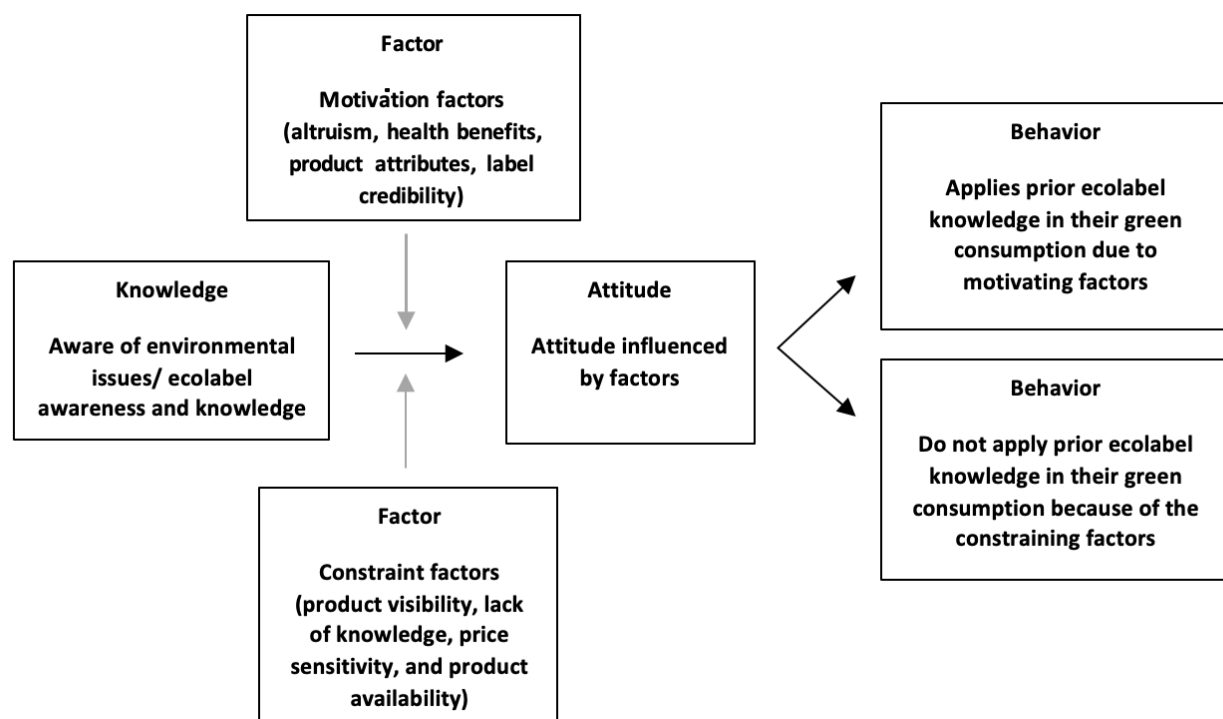


Figure 5: KAB model extended with the influencing factors

## 6. Conclusion

This study investigates factors that influence the application of consumer prior ecolabel knowledge in their green consumption. The result shows the factors to be Altruism, health benefit, product quality, label credibility, product visibility, price, lack of knowledge and product availability. Furthermore, findings showed that although consumers understand that eco-labelled products are produced less environmentally damagingly, they don't have the knowledge to interpret the messages the manufacturer is trying to pass across through the labels.

Therefore, they prioritise other things instead of using ecolabel knowledge in their consumption, such as price, lack of information, product visibility, and product availability. On the other hand, consumers with environmental expertise will strongly intend to purchase ecolabel products. Their motivating factors are altruism, health benefits, product attributes, and label credibility. These factors require the consumer to apply their ecolabel knowledge to their consumption.

### *Managerial Implication*

The aim of this study was to investigate what factors influences the application of consumers' prior ecolabel knowledge in the green consumptions, the findings reveals areas that both manufactures and store managers should pay more attention to. Therefore, the primary managerial implication of these findings relate to the communication channels and a new strategy to inform the consumer about the current environmental issues, what these eco-labels claim for, and the transparency. Manufactures should also reconsider making the product packaging more informative and outstanding and directly request store managers to place the product where the consumer can notice them. This might also require ecolabel products manufactures to develop a strategy to ensure that the eco-label product information is not greenwashing. Therefore, companies should provide an information platform and a fact sheet to enhance eco-label credibility.

### *Future research*

Researching which factors influence the application of consumers' prior ecolabel knowledge in their green consumption has been exciting. However, because of the limit the bachelor thesis imposes, we haven't been able to study all the aspects regarding factors influencing the application of consumers' ecolabel knowledge. Based on the findings of this study, it would be interesting if future research could investigate if having a more informative product packaging increases the purchase of eco-label products. In addition, our research indicated that one of the factors influencing consumers' application of knowledge and purchase behaviour is lack of knowledge.

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# Appendices

## *Appendix 1. Interview questions*

### **Interview questions**

Hello, thank you once again for agreeing to participate in this interview. I hope you understand that you can withdraw your consent anytime, and you don't have to answer any questions you are not comfortable with.

- Okay, so to start with, can you tell me a bit about yourself? Like your name, age, and whether you are working or studying right now?
- Where do you grow up? What are your hobbies?

Okay, now I'm going to start asking questions for the research question. We are currently exploring factors that influence the application of ecolabel knowledge/ or when buying green products.

1. So we would like to ask you a few questions about the environment and your grocery shopping practices.
  - What do you think about the environment nowadays?
  - Do you think climate change is a serious problem right now?
  - What are the environmental issues of concern to you right now?
  - Will you describe yourself as someone concerned about the environment? If yes, what are the things you do that demonstrate this? If not, why not?
  - With the general environmental challenges going on, what do you think we individuals can do to lessen our impact on these environmental challenges?
  - How will you describe your normal shopping process? (do you make a grocery list before shopping?) How often do you go shopping for groceries? (once or twice or a week?)
2. Have you ever noticed when these small labels on the product, like fruits, for example, when shopping?

- Are you aware that they are called eco-labels?
- When you hear the word eco-label, what do you associate them with?
- Do you recognise any of these labels? (*participants will be shown a couple of eco-labels*)



- Does seeing these labels now makes you want to change the answers you gave to my previous two questions (state the questions again to remind them.)
- When did you start noticing eco-labels on product packaging?
- What do you personally think about when you see a label on product packaging, what do you personally think about?

### 3. Would you consider yourself knowledgeable about eco-label?

- Would you consider yourself environmental conscious? Are you aware of the damage being done to the environment?
- In what product categories would you say you notice eco-label more on? For example, fresh produce like vegetables, bananas, fruits etc., dairy products such as milk, cheese, egg, or baby products in the store like pampers, baby milk, or household essentials such as tissue papers, detergents etc.
- Why do you think you notice eco-label more on some products than others?
- How often do you buy eco-label products, and which product categories will you say you buy more eco-labelled products from?

- So would you say that eco-labels affect your decisions when you are shopping?
4. When you buy green products/products with eco-labels on them, what are the things you consider.
- What are your thoughts when you select products with eco-labels on them? Does it influence whether you decide to buy them?
  - How do you apply your previous knowledge regarding eco-labels in your buying decisions?
5. Do you think you apply your knowledge about eco-label when you are shopping?
- Do you think you apply the knowledge of eco-label and your knowledge of the damage done to the environment when shopping?
6. How will you describe your thought process when deciding whether to buy a regular product or an eco-labelled one? For example, would you say when buying eco-labelled products, you buy them because you are aware that they are ecologically sourced.
- How do you think your knowledge is affected when you buy ecolabel products?
7. Generally speaking, having knowledge about something, in these cases eco-labels, does not necessarily mean we apply that knowledge during our shopping.
- Why do you think that happens?
  - How do you think people can be encouraged to apply the knowledge that buying eco-label products is better than one without one on them?

*Appendix 2. Participants Background information.*

| Participants Number | Age | Participant Occupation | Date          | Duration |
|---------------------|-----|------------------------|---------------|----------|
| 1                   | 40  | IT technician          | 17th of April | 40 min   |
| 2                   | 50  | Elderly home staff     | 18th of April | 45 min   |
| 3                   | -   | Librarian              | 18th of April | 30 min   |
| 4                   | -   | Teacher                | 18th of April | 44 min   |
| 5                   | 22  | Student                | 21th of April | 25 min   |
| 6                   | 23  | Student                | 21th of April | 30 min   |
| 7                   | 43  | Dental Nurse.          | 22nd of April | 40 min   |
| 8                   | 21  | Student                | 22nd of April | 34 min   |
| 9                   | 67  | Volunteer              | 23rd of April | 40 min   |